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An Expansive Imperial Articulation

ASHOKA'S MAIDEN EXCURSIONS IN PUBLIC COMMUNICATION were aimed at converting his audiences into adherents. 'Rock of ages cleft for me/Let me hide myself in thee' says the singer in the popular eighteenth-century Christian hymn, seeking refuge in Christ. 'Rock of ages cleft for me/Let me show myself in thee' would have been Ashoka's version, seeking exposure for the Buddha. It is perhaps not generally recognized that use of the autobiographical and confessional mode to propagate religious views, familiar to us in the Christian tradition from the time of the pioneering fourth century CE *Confessions of St Augustine*, was anticipated by over six centuries through Ashoka's virtual invention of the tradition, if not the genre, in the shape of his edicts. The short earlier versions whetted his appetite for such discourse. He seems to have grown ever more convinced that governance involved not just ruling well and prescribing policy but ensuring direct and affective communication with his subjects. So, around 256 BCE, some three years after his first edicts, he went on to elaborate and disseminate information on what appear to be very novel modes of governance, as well as norms of public and personal conduct. The contrast between this articulation and his earlier messages lay not merely in the spectrum of ideas and subjects outlined, nor only in the vivid combining of personal elements with political practice. It lay also in the length and elaborate nature of the new edicts, rendering them qualitatively different from the earlier short ones.

Ashoka's voice was first heard in edicts that ran from some six to twenty-two lines. 'Short' is a relative term, the relation being to the size of